

pictured as long-suffering, overworked and underpaid martyrs sacrificing themselves on the altars of education. Any criticism of either schools or teachers brings a storm of abusive protest.

Teachers' groups—and, egged on by them, parent-teacher associations—are quick to counterattack. The critic is characterized as an ogre who hates children and wishes to destroy civilization and bring about a return of the Dark Ages.

According to U.S. Office of Education figures, American schoolteachers' salaries have risen more than 1000 percent in the last 50 years or so. The average schoolteacher's salary today is over \$4000 per year. Would anyone in his right mind say that the quality of our educational standards has risen comparably—or risen at all—in the last half century?

Now, I did not choose these three examples because I have any particular axes to grind. I do not say that our foreign policy is bad, nor even that it necessarily needs any major overhaul. I am not trying to blame either capital or labor for any economic ills. In no way do I wish to imply that I believe all our schoolteachers are incompetent or undeserving of high praise or pay. I chose the examples at random, merely to point out the fallacy of thinking that everything is always all right everywhere. There are always many things that require investigations, critical examination and evaluation—and then possibly change and improvement—in all areas of our society.

The public at large cannot allow itself to be swayed from seeking needed reforms by entrenched bureaucrats, selfish

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minority groups or organizations which have their own, and far from altruistic, reasons for wishing to preserve the

status quo. In order that our society and its institutions may be strengthened there must be dissent. There must be dissenters who will seek out and point out the faults and abuses which exist or may develop.